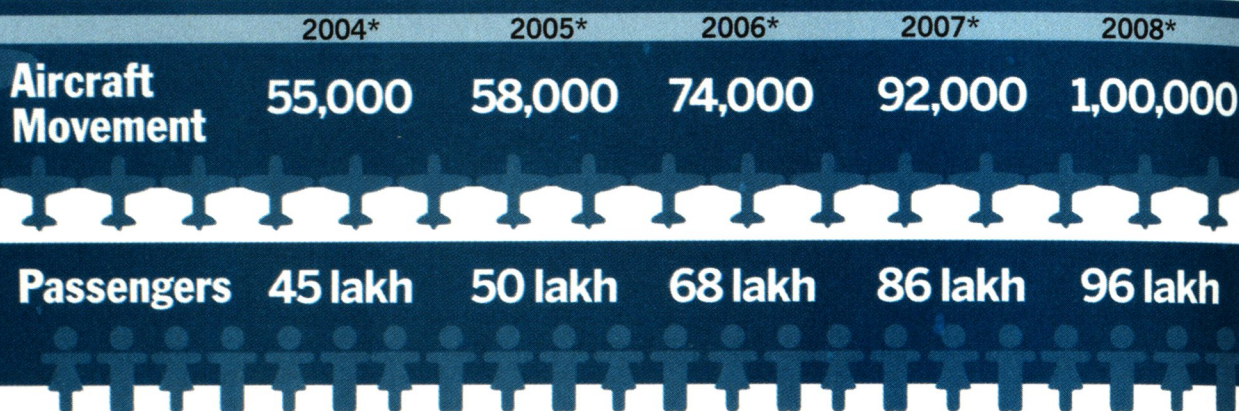


The Skyrocketing Growth of Traffic



* February data. Source: AAI

controllers have to work manually to enable pilots to reach them and land on the runway.

It is not just technology. There is a critical shortage of nearly 3,500 air traffic controllers all over the country. This means the current strength of 1,500 controllers has to put in two shifts a day every alternate day. Even as private developers struggle to increase capacity at airports, there seems to be no urgency from the Government to improve aviation and air traffic services. India is yet to get contiguous radar or VHF radio coverage. This means that once an aircraft flies out of an airport, it enters a black hole not covered either by a radar or radio. In such a situation, the ATC maintains a separation of eight nautical miles between aircraft. Pilots complain that developed countries like the US and the UK manage a horizontal separation (distance between two aircraft) of just 2.5 nautical miles, but in India controllers maintain a distance of at least 10 nautical miles between aircraft. This means that fewer aircraft can land or take off. "We maintain larger distances to compensate for the lack of infrastructure on the ground," admits an AAI official.

AAI officials say they have already ramped up movements at the Delhi

airport from 28 aircraft movements every day to nearly 42 per day in a single year—the maximum they can achieve in the present scenario. The explosive growth is already stretching key human resources, vital for running an airport, to break-point. At the Delhi airport, nearly 2,400 Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) personnel work in eight-hour shifts against a requirement of at least 3,500 personnel.

The installation of a new baggage screening system called in-line screening, which does away with passengers having to pre-screen their baggage at X-ray machines, has been

delayed at the Mumbai airport with CISF citing manpower shortage. Even in Hyderabad's new Rajiv Gandhi International Airport, there are long queues at the immigration counters and it can take over 30 minutes to get clearance and an hour or more to recover baggage. Such queues often force aircraft to wait on the tarmac, sacrificing a valuable take-off slot.

The old Bangalore airport, the country's third busiest, is dogged by a different set of problems—last month a dog crossed the path of a Kingfisher Airlines aircraft readying for take-off. The aircraft braked, swerved off the runway, destroying its landing gear. Fortunately, only four passengers were injured. Poor road connectivity means it takes people working in the southern and western part of the city, particularly the nearly five lakh-strong IT and BPO community, between 1.5 to three hours, depending on the time of travel to reach the new airport located 33 km north of the city.

It is not only the failure to build infrastructure but also to anticipate growth that is proving to be a speed breaker. At Amritsar's Raja Sansi International Airport a new Rs 70-crore terminal was commissioned last year to handle a 6 to 7 per cent traffic growth when international passenger traffic had already been growing at 165 per cent in the past three years to reach 5.96 lakh passengers last year. Not surprisingly, chaos reigns at the airport. At the Mumbai airport, current air traffic growth will saturate the designed capacity of 40 million passengers in



PEAK HOUR AIR CONGESTION

A frequent flier, Jaiprakashan encounters delays frequently. Recently spent an hour hovering over Mumbai airport close to midnight.

"I now leave a day early to arrive in time for a meeting."

V.G. JAIPRAKASHAN
MD, RGSOBORCONSERVICE INDIA